PATTADAKAL UNESCO WORLD HERITAGE SITE (??????????)

OVERVIEW AND HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Pattadakal, also known as Raktapura or Pattada Kisuvolal, is a historic complex of 7th and 8th century CE Hindu and Jain temples located in northern Karnataka. Situated on the west bank of the sacred Malaprabha River in Bagalkot district, it was the principal coronation site (Pattadakallu) for kings of the Early Chalukya dynasty of Badami.

ARCHITECTURAL SIGNIFICANCE

Pattadakal represents the pinnacle of early South Indian temple development and is globally renowned for illustrating the harmonious confluence of northern Nagara (Rekha-Nagara) and southern Dravida architectural traditions. The monuments were designated a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1987. The temples feature magnificent red-golden sandstone sourced from nearby Malaprabha valley quarries.

KEY TEMPLES AND MONUMENTS AT PATTADAKAL

1. Virupaksha Temple (Lokeshwara):
The grandest temple at Pattadakal, commissioned around 740 CE by Queen Lokamahadevi to celebrate her husband King Vikramaditya II's victory over the Pallavas of Kanchipuram. Built in sophisticated Dravida style with an imposing vimana, massive monolithic Nandi pavilion, and black stone Shiva Linga in the inner sanctum. The perimeter walls display intricate relief friezes of the Ramayana and Mahabharata.

2. Mallikarjuna Temple (Trailokyeshwara):
Built concurrently by Vikramaditya II's second queen, Trailokyamahadevi, to celebrate the same Kanchi military campaign. It mirrors the Dravida plan of Virupaksha on a slightly smaller scale.

3. Sangameshwara Temple:
The oldest surviving temple at the site, commissioned by King Vijayaditya (696?733 CE). Designed in classical early Dravida style with serene simplicity.

4. Papanatha Temple:
A 740 CE temple showcasing northern Nagara architecture with a curvilinear shikhara, decorative gavaksha arches, and detailed Ramayana narratives along its outer plinth.

5. Jain Narayana Temple:
A 9th-century CE temple from the Rashtrakuta period featuring a three-tiered Dravida vimana and large stone elephant sculptures flanking the mukhamandapa.